

We are software engineering students. We made process decisions for

LearnLoop, a startup with teams in Amsterdam, Bangalore, and Austin.

These were our choices: SITUATION A - WHOSE DESIGN WINS?

Amsterdam has designed a user interface that requires real-time

personalisation data streamed from the backend.

Bangalore says this is technically impossible with the current

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Your choices are defensible, but if you're preparing for a software engineering or project management discussion, you'll often score higher by showing that you understand the trade-offs and can argue the other side. Here are the strongest arguments against your decisions.

Situation A – Whose Design Wins?

Your choice: Option 3

Ship the MVP with weaker UX, then redesign after the pilot customer has seen it.

Strongest argument for Option 2 (the redesign)

The biggest risk is not missing the deadline—it is delivering an MVP that fails to prove product value.

If Amsterdam's design relies on real-time personalization and that capability is central to the product vision, then shipping a weaker version could create a false negative with the pilot customer. The customer may conclude that LearnLoop is not useful, even though the "real" product would have been much better.

From a team-dynamics perspective:

- Amsterdam may feel that engineering is dictating product strategy.
- Designers may become disengaged if major UX decisions are repeatedly sacrificed.
- Technical debt grows because the redesign still has to happen later.
- Bangalore's concerns are addressed properly rather than postponed.

Under a 9-month deadline, a 3-month redesign is painful, but losing the pilot customer because the MVP underwhelms them could be even more damaging than slipping the schedule.

Your authority answer: Product Manager

Challenge: If the disagreement is fundamentally technical rather than product-related, the Product Manager should not act alone.

A stronger governance model might be:

- Product Manager decides business priorities.
- Technical Lead/Architect decides technical feasibility.
- If they disagree, the issue escalates to a steering group or executive sponsor.

Otherwise, teams may perceive decisions as politically motivated rather than evidence-based.

Situation B – The Only Meeting Slot

Your choice: Drop Item 1 (finalising the data model)

Strongest argument for keeping Item 1 and dropping Item 2

Item 1 is a blocker.

The scenario explicitly states that Bangalore cannot proceed without the data model. Every day this remains unresolved risks slowing development across multiple sprints.

In contrast:

- Austin's customer call may be able to proceed with provisional answers.
- Requirement reviews can often happen asynchronously through documentation and comments.
- Architecture conflicts have already been unresolved for two weeks; another few days may not change much.

Under deadline pressure, removing blockers is usually the highest-priority activity because blocked developers generate no progress.

Challenge to your handling approach

You wrote:

"We hear out both sides and then prepare a solution which makes everyone happy."

The strongest criticism is that this may be unrealistic.

In distributed teams, many conflicts involve genuine trade-offs where someone will be unhappy:

- Better UX vs. faster delivery
- Technical quality vs. schedule
- Product scope vs. engineering effort

Waiting for a solution that satisfies everyone can delay decisions. Sometimes leadership must make a decision even when one team disagrees.

A stronger answer might be:

"Handle the item asynchronously through a decision document. Collect input from all teams, assign a decision owner, and set a deadline for the final decision so the work does not stall."

Situation C – The Legal Blocker

Your choice: Option 3

Move Bangalore to another area of the product while legal is resolved.

Strongest argument for Option 2 (build on synthetic data)

The recommendation engine is likely a core feature.

By switching Bangalore to another product area:

- The recommendation engine starts later.
- Knowledge gained from early experimentation is delayed.
- The team may spend weeks on lower-priority work.

Using synthetic data allows:

- Algorithm development.
- Architecture validation.
- Performance testing.
- Early discovery of design flaws.

Even if rework is required later, the team continues learning and moving forward rather than postponing one of the product's most complex components.

From a deadline perspective:

- Recommendation systems are notoriously difficult to estimate.
- Delaying work until legal approval arrives may compress testing and integration into the final months.
- Some rework may be cheaper than losing 6–8 weeks of progress on a critical feature.

Challenge to your communication approach

You wrote:

"We say it as it is..."

Transparency is good, but the strongest counterargument is that "just telling them" may not be enough.

A distributed team that suddenly loses a major workstream can interpret the decision as:

- Lack of trust.
- Poor planning.
- Their work being deprioritized.

A stronger communication strategy would be:

1. Explain the legal constraint.
2. Explain why continuing would create risk.
3. Show how the reassigned work supports the MVP.
4. Clarify when the recommendation-engine work will resume.
5. Invite questions and concerns.

This keeps morale higher and reduces frustration during the context switch.

Overall assessment

Your decisions consistently prioritize **meeting the 9-month MVP deadline**, which is a valid project-management strategy.

The strongest criticism across all three situations is that you often **defer difficult technical or product problems to protect the schedule**. The alternative viewpoint is that some issues—core architecture, blocked dependencies, and recommendation-engine development—may be so fundamental that delaying them creates larger risks later.

A professor or interviewer would likely be most impressed if you acknowledge both sides:

"We chose the option that best protected the MVP deadline, but we recognize that it increases technical debt and could reduce product quality. The alternative option would have reduced long-term risk at the cost of short-term schedule pressure."

That demonstrates awareness of both delivery pressure and engineering quality concerns.

